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SOCIAL JUSTICE IN BIHAR: ENDEAVOURING TOWARDS EQUALITY AND INCLUSION OF OBCS INTO MAINSTREAM

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Introduction

Social justice, a concept rooted in fairness, equality, and inclusivity, plays a vital role in shaping a just and harmonious society. In India, a nation known for its rich cultural diversity, social justice has been a prominent topic of discussion and action. This article explores the progress of social justice in Bihar, highlighting the efforts made to address inequality, discrimination, and empower backwards communities.ⁱ

This article also emphasises on the different types of initiatives taken in Bihar to strengthen the OBC community and going to mainstream, there are several limitations and difficulties associated with the possibility of evolving an analytic framework for the study of state politics within the framework of federalism. There are some “variables” like caste, class, economy, education, voting behaviour, health, agriculture, industrial growth, gender, race, health etc. which affect or help in developing the mechanism for the study of state politics.ⁱⁱ

Historical Background

India's history is marked by centuries of social stratification and systemic discrimination based on caste, religion, gender, and economic status. The caste system, deeply entrenched for centuries, created a hierarchical social order that perpetuated inequality and denied basic human rights to certain groups. Additionally, gender-based discrimination and religious conflicts have posed significant challenges to achieving social justice. Social justice is a fundamental principle that aims to ensure fairness, equality, and opportunity for all members of society. In Bihar, social justice plays a crucial role in addressing the needs and concerns of Other Backward Classes (OBCs), who have historically faced social and economic disadvantages. OBC is a multi-dimensional one; to understand its many facets, a sound knowledge with these disciplines is the most competent to contribute to proper understanding and critical appreciation of the issues concerning the OBC.ⁱⁱⁱ

The government of Bihar has taken significant steps to promote social justice and uplift OBC communities. Through various policies, schemes, and initiatives, the state aims to provide equal opportunities, representation, and access to resources for OBCs. These efforts include the implementation of reservation policies, where a certain percentage of seats in educational institutions, government jobs, and elected bodies are reserved for OBCs. This ensures their representation and allows them to participate actively in decision-making processes. Additionally, Bihar has introduced welfare schemes specifically designed to empower OBCs.

These schemes focus on areas such as education, employment, entrepreneurship, healthcare, and financial assistance. Scholarships, skill development programs, financial support for business ventures, and affordable loans are some of the initiatives aimed at improving the socio-economic status of OBC communities.^{iv}

Furthermore, awareness campaigns, social programs, and legal measures have been undertaken to address social discrimination and prejudices faced by OBCs. These efforts aim to create a more inclusive and harmonious society where every individual, regardless of their social background, is treated with dignity and respect. Social justice for OBCs in Bihar is an ongoing endeavour, as the government continues to identify and address the specific challenges faced by these communities. The commitment to social justice reflects the state's dedication to building an equitable society where every individual has the opportunity to thrive and contribute to the overall development of Bihar. The history of Other



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Backward Classes (OBCs) in Bihar, like in other parts of India, is characterized by a long-standing struggle for social and economic empowerment. OBCs in Bihar belong to diverse castes and communities, each with their own unique history and socio-cultural background.

The term "Other Backward Classes" refers to those groups that were historically marginalized and faced socio-economic disadvantages. The OBC category includes various castes and communities that were traditionally excluded from positions of power and privilege. These communities often faced discrimination and limited access to education, employment, and other resources. Bihar, being a historically significant region, has witnessed various social and political movements led by OBC communities seeking social justice and equal opportunities. These movements aimed to challenge the prevailing caste-based hierarchy and demand greater representation and inclusion in governance and decision-making processes.

The implementation of reservation policies has been a significant milestone in the history of OBCs in Bihar. Reservation ensures a certain percentage of seats in educational institutions, government jobs, and elected bodies are reserved for OBC candidates. This policy has provided opportunities for OBC communities to access education, secure employment, and actively participate in the political landscape. Over the years, the Bihar government has implemented several welfare and development schemes to uplift OBC communities. These initiatives focus on education, skill development, entrepreneurship, healthcare, and financial assistance. These efforts aim to bridge the socio-economic gap and provide OBCs with the necessary resources and support to enhance their overall well-being. While, progress has been made in terms of social empowerment, there are still challenges that need to be addressed. Issues like poverty, lack of quality education, and limited access to healthcare facilities continue to affect OBC communities in Bihar. The government and various organizations are working towards addressing these challenges and ensuring that OBCs have equal opportunities for growth and development.

It is important to recognize that the history of OBCs in Bihar, like any other community, is diverse and multifaceted. The experiences and struggles of OBC communities vary within the state, and it is crucial to understand and acknowledge the specific histories and needs of each OBC caste and community in Bihar.

Empowering Backward Communities

Bihar, a land rich in history and diversity, is home to numerous Other Backward Classes (OBC) communities. These communities have long been marginalized, facing social and economic challenges that hindered their progress. However, the government of Bihar, recognizing the importance of social justice and inclusivity, has undertaken significant efforts to empower and uplift OBC communities, ensuring equal opportunities for all. Recognizing the need for social justice, the Bihar government has implemented various policies and initiatives to address systemic inequalities and promote inclusivity. Affirmative action measures, such as reservations in education and employment, aim to provide opportunities to historically disadvantaged communities, particularly Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and Other Backward Classes. To strengthen Other Backward Classes (OBCs) in Bihar, several measures can be taken. Here are some possible steps that can be implemented to empower and uplift the OBC communities in the state:

1. **Reservation Policies:** Bihar has given 27% reservation to OBCs. It is further sub categorised into EBCs to ensure effective implementation of reservation policies for OBCs in education, employment, and government schemes. This will provide them with equitable opportunities and representation.
2. **Education and Skill Development:** Focus on improving access to quality education and skill development programs for OBC students. This can include setting up special coaching centres, scholarships, and vocational training initiatives to enhance their employability. One of the key pillars of empowerment lies in education. The Bihar government has implemented various schemes to promote education among OBC communities. Scholarships and financial aid programs have been introduced to support OBC students in pursuing higher education, enabling them to overcome financial barriers



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and reach their full potential. Skill development programs have also been initiated to enhance employability and entrepreneurship skills, equipping OBC youth with the necessary tools for success.

3. Entrepreneurship and Financial Support: Encourage entrepreneurship among OBC communities by providing financial assistance, business development training, and mentorship programs. This can help them start their own ventures and contribute to the state's economy.

4. Healthcare and Welfare: Ensuring access to quality healthcare is crucial for the overall well-being of OBC communities. Bihar has implemented targeted healthcare programs, including special camps and awareness campaigns, to address the specific health needs of OBC individuals. Additionally, welfare schemes have been introduced to provide social support, uplift living standards, and improve the quality of life for OBC families.

5. Infrastructure Development: Invest in the development of infrastructure in OBC-dominated areas, including roads, schools, hospitals, and sanitation facilities. This will improve their living conditions and provide better access to basic amenities.

6. Empowerment through Representation: Encourage OBC representation in local governance bodies, legislative assemblies, and administrative positions. This will provide them with a platform to voice their concerns and contribute to decision-making processes.

7. Awareness and Social Campaigns: Conduct awareness campaigns to eliminate social discrimination and prejudices against OBCs. Promote inclusivity, equality, and respect for diversity through various mediums like media, workshops, and community engagement programs.

8. Research and Data Collection: Conduct comprehensive research and data collection on the socio-economic status, educational attainment, and overall well-being of OBC communities. This will help in formulating targeted policies and interventions to address their specific needs effectively.

It is important to note that the implementation of these measures should be done in consultation with OBC communities and their leaders, taking into account their specific requirements and aspirations. Additionally, regular monitoring and evaluation of the initiatives will help in identifying gaps and making necessary improvements.

Government Initiatives (OBC and its constituents division)

In Bihar, there are several schemes and initiatives aimed at the welfare and empowerment of Other Backward Classes (OBCs). These schemes are designed to address various aspects of their development, including education, employment, healthcare, and social upliftment. Here are some prominent OBC schemes in Bihar:

1. Mukhyamantri Nischay Swayam Sahayata Bhatta Yojana^v: This scheme provides financial assistance to unemployed youth from OBC and economically backward sections to start their own enterprises. Under this scheme, eligible candidates receive a monthly allowance for a certain period to support their entrepreneurial ventures.

2. Mukhyamantri Alpasankhyak Rojgar Rin Yojana^{vi}: This scheme aims to promote self-employment among OBCs and other minority communities by providing loans at concessional rates of interest. It assists in setting up small-scale industries, businesses, or service enterprises.

3. Bihar Post-Matric Scholarship Scheme: This scholarship program provides financial assistance to OBC students pursuing post-matriculation courses, including degree, diploma, and professional courses. The scholarship covers tuition fees, maintenance allowances, and other educational expenses.



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4. Kanya Utthan Yojana: This scheme focuses on the education and welfare of girls belonging to OBCs and economically weaker sections. It provides financial support for the education of girls from Class 1 to graduation level and also offers incentives for their marriage after attaining the legal age.

5. Bihar Backward Class Finance and Development Corporation (BCFDCC): This corporation facilitates the economic empowerment of OBCs by providing financial assistance for income-generating activities. It offers loans, subsidies, and skill development training to individuals and self-help groups from OBC communities.

6. Mukhyamantri Kanya Vivah Yojana: This scheme aims to encourage the marriage of girls from economically weaker OBC families by providing financial assistance. It offers a one-time grant to eligible families to support the marriage expenses.

7. Free Coaching Scheme: The Bihar government provides free coaching for competitive examinations like Civil Services, Staff Selection Commission (SSC), Banking, Railways, etc., to OBC students. The scheme provides economic support for rupees 50,000 if clear the exam BPSC (PT) and 1,00,000 for UPSC (PT). This initiative helps them in preparing for competitive exams and enhances their chances of employment in government services. These are some of the key schemes implemented by the Bihar government for the welfare and upliftment of OBC communities. It is important to note that the availability and details of these schemes may vary, and it is advisable to visit the official government websites or contact relevant authorities for the most up-to-date and accurate information.

Empowering OBCs through Political Participation

Upper backward castes										
Caste	1967	1969	1972	1977	1980	1985	1990	1995	2000	
Yadav	37	47	35	51	46	47	63	86	64	
Kurmi	14	12	20	21	20	12	12	13	12	
Koeri	13	13	8	6	12	18	18	27	22	
Baniya	13	16	8	10	13	9	18	18	12	
Total	77	88	71	88	91	86	111	144	110	
Lower backward castes										
Kahar	1		1				1	3	1	
Dhanuk	2		1					1	2	
Tattma	1							1	1	
Nai	1	1	1	1	1	1		1	1	
Mallah		2	1		2	2	2	1	4	
Bhaant			1							
Kharwaar		1	1	1			1	1		
Noniaa				1	2		1	2	1	
Badhai				1						
Gangota							1	2	1	
Kewat							1	2	2	
Rajwaar								1		
Paneri										
Total	5	5	6	4	5	3	6	16	11	

Note- This data is taken from the Routledge Handbook of the Other Backward classes in India^{vii}



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This table shows the OBCs participation in Bihar during the rule of the Lalu and his party RJD. development is the part of the part of the historical processes which help to strengthen the cause of the backward classes. it was not that Lalu group was the only architect of the OBCs development. If we see the trends of OBCs participation then, in 1990 there were excessive participation of Lower caste leaders in the State legislature Assembly. This shows the participation of the OBCs group in the state assembly.

Organizations and Movements

Numerous grassroots organizations and social justice movements have emerged across India, working tirelessly to challenge discriminatory practices and fight for the rights of marginalized communities. Dalit movements, women's rights organizations, and human rights activists have been at the forefront of these efforts, advocating for equal opportunities, representation, and the eradication of social prejudices. In Bihar, the movement for the backward class was somewhat identified with the RJD, Yadavs, and Lalu Prasad Yadav. The dominance of Yadavs within the RJD and the acceptance of lawlessness as a means to justify the backward class movement caused discomfort among many leaders of the backward classes. Consequently, non-Yadav leaders from the backward classes, such as Nitish Kumar, Ram Vilas Paswan, and others, formed their own political parties. They joined forces with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), the main opponent of the RJD and a party supported by the forward castes. This significantly weakened Lalu Prasad Yadav's position. Additionally, Mayawati began to make inroads into a portion of the Scheduled Caste votes. As a result, in the 2000 state assembly elections, Lalu Prasad Yadav was unable to secure a majority and had to form an alliance with the Congress in order to retain power.

Challenges and the Path Ahead

While significant strides have been made, challenges persist on the path to achieving social justice in India. Caste-based discrimination continues to be a deeply rooted issue, impacting various aspects of life, including education, employment, and social mobility. Gender inequality remains a concern, with issues such as violence against women, unequal pay, and limited representation in decision-making positions needing urgent attention.

Addressing these challenges requires a multifaceted approach that involves legislative reforms, educational interventions, and changing societal attitudes. Strengthening the implementation of existing policies, creating awareness about social justice issues, and promoting inclusivity at all levels of society are crucial steps.

Conclusion

Bihar's journey towards social justice has been marked by progress and challenges. While the government's initiatives and the tireless efforts of organizations and movements have brought about positive change, there is still much work to be done. Achieving social justice in Bihar necessitates the collective efforts of individuals, communities, civil society organizations, and policymakers to create a society where equality, fairness, and inclusion are the guiding principles. Only by embracing diversity and challenging discriminatory practices can Bihar move closer to its vision of a just and inclusive society for all. The journey towards empowering OBC communities in Bihar is an ongoing effort rooted in the principles of social justice and equality. The government's commitment to uplift OBC communities through education, reservation policies, entrepreneurship, healthcare, and awareness programs is commendable. However, there is still work to be done to address the socio-economic challenges faced by OBC communities fully. By continuing to implement and expand these empowering initiatives, Bihar can create a society where every individual, regardless of their social background, has equal opportunities to thrive and contribute. Through collective efforts and inclusive policies, Bihar can truly become a model of empowerment and progress for OBC communities, ensuring a brighter and more inclusive future for all.



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^{vi} <https://biharonlineportal.com/mukhyamantri-alpsankhyak-rojgar-rin-yojana>

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